

Hackathon Challenge 2 - Tracking Power: What we can and can't see

Presented by OpenSanctions, this challenge invites participants to investigate the global landscape of Politically Exposed Persons (PEP) data - focusing on coverage, gaps, and data quality across countries and regions.

PEP data, information about individuals who hold or have held prominent public positions, is essential for transparency, anti-money-laundering (AML) compliance, and financial integrity. Yet coverage varies widely, with some countries providing detailed public registers and others offering little to no accessible information. This fragmentation creates blind spots in global financial systems that deserve careful scrutiny.

Our project

In this project, we aim to answer the following question:

Is there a pattern behind PEPs with sanctions?

To do so, we developed a full analytical workflow to examine the relationship between Politically Exposed Persons (PEPs) and sanctioned entities across ten globally influential countries, selected based on World Population Review, using our API. We also included Spain to represent our own national context. Additionally, we assign each PEP a risk category (high, medium, or low).

The results show that the total number of Politically Exposed Persons (PEPs) in a country is primarily influenced by the size and complexity of its government. Countries such as the United States and France have very large PEP populations but relatively low sanction match percentages (below 5%), reflecting extensive governmental structures with broad public-sector coverage.

In contrast, countries like Russia, China, and Saudi Arabia display significantly higher sanction match percentages despite having fewer total PEPs. This suggests that geopolitical position, international scrutiny, and political alignment play a major role in determining whether PEPs appear in sanctions datasets. Notably, countries closely aligned with major sanction-issuing bodies—such as Germany, Japan, and France—show extremely low sanction ratios.

Overall, the findings indicate that sanctions data should not be interpreted solely as a measure of corruption. Instead, meaningful analysis emerges when sanction ratios are evaluated alongside government size, international relations, and enforcement bias.

Using the sanctions dataset in conjunction with an external global population dataset, we examined the relationship between the number of sanctions issued by each country and its population size. The findings indicate that countries with the highest sanctions per capita are predominantly small nations and island states. Even with extended analysis, most of the highest sanctions coefficients are associated with small island countries, where relatively low populations tend to amplify the per-capita measures.

Some large countries demonstrate high sanctions coefficients, suggesting that factors beyond population, such as geopolitical and economic aspects, also play a role. Overall, the analysis indicates that while smaller countries generally exhibit higher sanctions per capita, both small and large nations can display elevated sanctions coefficients depending on their specific geopolitical and economic contexts.

In conclusion...

This project demonstrates that transparency datasets such as PEP and sanctions lists reveal as much about global power structures as they do about individual accountability. By combining high-confidence entity matching with cross-country analysis, we show that sanction exposure among Politically Exposed Persons is unevenly distributed and strongly influenced by geopolitical alignment, government structure, and international enforcement dynamics.

Our findings highlight the importance of contextualized analysis. Sanctions data alone cannot serve as a proxy for corruption or wrongdoing; instead, it must be interpreted alongside political, institutional, and demographic factors. Misinterpretation risks reinforcing biases and obscuring real governance challenges.

Ultimately, our work emphasizes the need for more transparent, globally consistent public data on political power and accountability. Strengthening open datasets and improving comparability across countries can help regulators, researchers, and civil society better identify blind spots in financial oversight and promote fairer, more effective global governance.